Bihar has long been known as the focal point for all things Buddhism. For pilgrims and history buffs, there are many wonderful sites to explore in the state. Here is our pick of the most fascinating ones that avid travellers must add to their Bihar itinerary...

Jehanabad: The incredibly well-preserved **Barabar hill caves** here are said to be India's oldest surviving rock-cut caves. Dating back to the third century BC to the times of Emperor Ashoka, they are carved from granite, and the interiors are a great example of 'Mauryan polish', said to have been the influence of Alexander the Great's presence. Ancient sculptures and inscriptions can be seen in the four caves named Karan Chaupar, Lomas Rishi, Sudama and Visvakarma. If you'd like to explore more, there's another clutch of caves that come under the Nagarjuni hill cluster, built slightly later and called Gopika, Vedathika and Vapiya.



Photographs by SHUTTERSTOCK



Bodh Gaya: This is perhaps the most important place on Bihar's Buddhist circuit. The spot where Gautama is said to have attained enlightenment under the Bodhi Tree to become Lord Buddha, is here. As is the imposing Gupta-era **Mahabodhi Temple** with a 170-f00t-tall shikhara and evidence of pilgrims visiting between the seventh and tenth century from countries such as Sri Lanka, Myanmar and China. It is now a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Other locations linked to the Buddha's meditation, several stupas and monasteries built by various Buddhist kingdoms are all worth visiting. If size matters, then you'll love the Buddha statue, all of 80 feet tall, dating back to 1989.



Nalanda: The ruins of what was once one of the world's greatest universities in the fifth century are impressive even by modern standards, making it a must-see UNESCO World Heritage Site. When you take in the massive buildings constructed of red brick, you can imagine the 2,000 teachers who once taught more than 10,000 students here. The prime seat of Buddhist teachings at the time, it attracted scholars from across the world. Don't miss the archaeological museum, brimming with stunning statues and interesting items from daily life in Nalanda. Just 15 km away is Rajgir, as the ancient city of Rajgriha is now known. The capital of several dynasties of rulers, it was also where Lord Buddha, as well as Lord Mahavir, spent several years. Don't miss the remnants of the 40-km-long Cyclopean Wall made of limestone boulders, which was built 2,500 years ago to protect the ancient city from invaders.